Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Journal of Personal Selling & Sales Management

ISSN: 0885-3134 (Print) 1557-7813 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rpss20

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Journal of Personal Selling & Sales Management, 2015
Vol. 35, No. 2, 143–163, http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/08853134.2015.1010542

Rogues in the ranks of selling organizations: using corporate ethics to manage workplace bullying and job satisfaction

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(*Received 16 January 2015; accepted 19 January 2015*)

The literature recognizes that the sales profession is an inherently competitive and self-interested occupation that can be negatively impacted by deviant behavior and rationalizations of unethical conduct. The unique boundary-spanning nature and autonomy of such work means that there is often little management oversight of sales professionals' behavior, which may lead to misbehavior and poor work attitudes. Yet, evidence suggests that the development of corporate ethical values (CEVs) can mitigate concerns about unethical conduct, suggesting that these principles might be used to reduce workplace bullying and enhance job satisfaction. Using a self-report questionnaire, information was collected from national and regional samples of selling professionals employed in different organizations located in the USA (N = 356). While controlling for the effects of sampling and social desirability, results indicated that increased communication of an ethics code was associated with stronger perceptions of CEVs, while ethical values were negatively related to perceptions of workplace bullying and positively related to job satisfaction. Workplace bullying was also negatively related to job satisfaction. The findings suggest that an ethical work environment should be instituted in sales organizations to reduce misconduct and enhance work attitudes.

Keywords: corporate ethical values; workplace bullying; job satisfaction

The management of ethics in sales organizations is an ongoing concern given that selling professionals must negotiate ethical quandaries in a job that requires boundary-spanning (i.e., balancing organizational and customer needs) and autonomous decision-making (Caywood and Laczniak 1986; Serviere-Munoz and Mallin 2013; Wotruba 1990). The work can be competitive; managerial and organizational directives/practices are sometimes sketchy and/or conflicting; and colleagues can behave inappropriately (Ferrell, Johnston, and Ferrell 2007; Hoffman, Howe, and Hardigree 1991; Tellefsen and Eyuboglu 2002), qualities that can encourage questionable and risky behaviors. As a result, selling professionals sometimes exhibit high degrees of self-interest (Singhapakdi and Vitell 1992) and can operate in ways that are self-serving. As such, they might be motivated to develop social networks for self-benefit (Seevers, Skinner, and Kelley 2007) and rationalize their misbehaviors by neutralizing any feelings of dissonance that stem from acting unethically (Serviere-Munoz and Mallin 2013).

One emerging problem that can harm sales organizations is employee deviant behavior, which represents actions that run counter to accepted work group norms of conduct (Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010). Such conduct is voluntary and generally possesses the capacity to negatively impact a company and its employees (Robinson and Bennett 1995). For instance, stealing from an employer, sabotaging the workplace, committing fraud, sexually harassing others, threatening colleagues, consuming illegal drugs, and vandalizing company property would all be considered acts of a deviant nature (Bennett and Robinson 2000). Considering the wide scope and seriousness of such negative conduct, deviant behavior can cripple organizations both financially and operationally (Bennett and Robinson 2000; Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010).

Research suggests that deviate behaviors occur frequently in organizations (Bennett and Robinson 2000; Lawrence and Robinson 2007; Robinson and Bennett 1995), but misconduct appears to be particularly prevalent in the sales profession (Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010). Salespersons can lie to customers when making sales calls (Strout 2002), focus on sales quotas at the expense of satisfying customers' needs (Strout 2002), and

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Manuscript prepared for the special ethics issue of *Journal of Personal Selling & Sales Management*.
This study was presented at the *International Journal of Arts and Sciences' (IJAS)* International Conference for Academic Disciplines, October 28–31, American University of Rome, Rome, Italy.

use questionable tactics to close deals (Murray 2002). Making matters worse is the apparent acceptance of deviant behavior as a means for achieving personal and professional gain:

> The alarming prevalence of deviance among salespeople may be due, in part, to an inherent leniency toward deviant behavior within the sales industry … sales managers generally administer less severe discipline to their top sales performers than to their poorer sales performers for engaging in unacceptable selling behavior. The economic pressures resulting from an ongoing recession and an unprecedented financial crisis may cause salespeople to view deviant behavior as a matter of survival, or a way of 'making ends meet' in spite of their recognition that those activities are clear violations of important organizational norms. (Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010, 239)

While there are different types of deviant behaviors, 'interpersonal deviance' is particularly challenging because co-workers are 'bullied' at work; this can include taking someone's sales leads, failing to be a team player, and harassing others verbally, psychologically, and/or emotionally (Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010). One study using a large sample of sales managers determined that many individuals surveyed had to deal with competitive pressures that existed among their sales professionals, such as disagreements over sales territories/leads and increased suspicions that selling opportunities were taken by colleagues (Stewart 2003). These findings suggest that deviant behaviors in sales organizations are reflective of a broader concern regarding poor employee relations in the profession, and that an understanding of workplace bullying might be a more appropriate way to consider much of the interpersonal misconduct that occurs among selling professionals. The importance of addressing bullying among sales professionals is underscored by the Ethics Resource Center (ERC) data in 2013 that shows abusive (bullying) behavior is often a top-ranked ethical issue that companies face (NBES 2013). Therefore, given this gap in the sales ethics literature, one of the primary goals and focal contributions of this study is to explore the concept of workplace bullying and its potential relationship with job satisfaction within the sales profession, with an eye toward identifying key corporate ethical processes that might be used to reduce such misconduct. Related theory is also subsequently discussed related to corporate ethics and job satisfaction. Figure 1 highlights the focal relationships explored in this investigation.

The remainder of the study addresses these focal relationships, namely corporate ethics, including codes and corporate ethical values (CEVs), workplace bullying, and job satisfaction. The importance and rationale of the study is then presented, followed by the method, results, and discussion.

Workplace bullying

Notwithstanding discussions of deviant behavior (Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010), workplace bullying has not been investigated in the sales literature; however, the construct has received attention in other managerial fields. Addressing bullying is warranted in the sales context because of the unique boundary-spanning nature and autonomy found in the profession. There is no concise definition of workplace bullying (Bartlett and Bartlett 2011), but the term 'counterproductive workplace behavior' (Spector and Fox 2010) is often used to describe a variety of similar constructs that point to generalized abuse and mistreatment, mobbing, and incivility directed toward co-workers (Bulutlar and Oz 2009; Hoel and Beale 2006; Vickers 2010). Other conceptions of workplace mistreatment and bullying include abusive supervision, emotional/workplace abuse, incivility, interpersonal conflict, social undermining, victimization, and workplace aggression (Hershcovis 2011). Einarsen (1999, 17) suggests that the terms bullying and mobbing both refer to 'the systematic persecution of a colleague, a subordinate or a superior, which, if continued, may cause severe social, psychological and psychosomatic problems for the victim.' Bullying can also be used to control others (Boddy 2011) with an intention to inflict harm on another party (either perceived or actual; Bulutlar and Oz 2009; Einarsen 1999; Vickers 2001) and can occur regardless of any consequences (Vickers 2010).

There is also no unified set of behaviors attached to workplace bullying (Rayner and Cooper 2006; Soylu 2011), yet there is agreement about certain acts that qualify. For instance, bullying can consist of unwarranted criticism (Boddy 2011), social isolation (Zapf 1999; Zapf and Einarsen 2001; Zapf, Knorz, and Kulla 1996; Rodríguez-Muñoz and Moreno-Jiméz 2010), name-calling, and (sexual) harassment (Harvey et al. 2007). Further, the undermining of professional skills (Zapf and Einarsen 2001), victimization, persistent embarrassment, insulting comments, humiliation (Vickers 2010), verbal threats, and the spreading of rumors (Zapf 1999) are also considered to be bullying. There is also agreement that bullying is often psychological in nature (Einarsen et al. 2011; Leymann 1996). It is understood that bullies intentionally harm others (e.g., Hershcovis 2011; Vickers 2001) to force them to act in predetermined ways (Boddy 2011). As such, bullying can take the form of offensive, malicious, intimidating, or unjustified abusive punishment (Einarsen et al. 2011). On the extreme end, bullying can entail humiliating, threatening/violent behavior, and physical aggression (Einarsen et al. 2011).

With regard to frequency, workplace bullying occurs somewhat often and over extended periods of time (Devonish 2013; Einarsen 1999; Einarsen et al. 2011; Hershcovis 2011; Leymann 1996). These patterns suggest

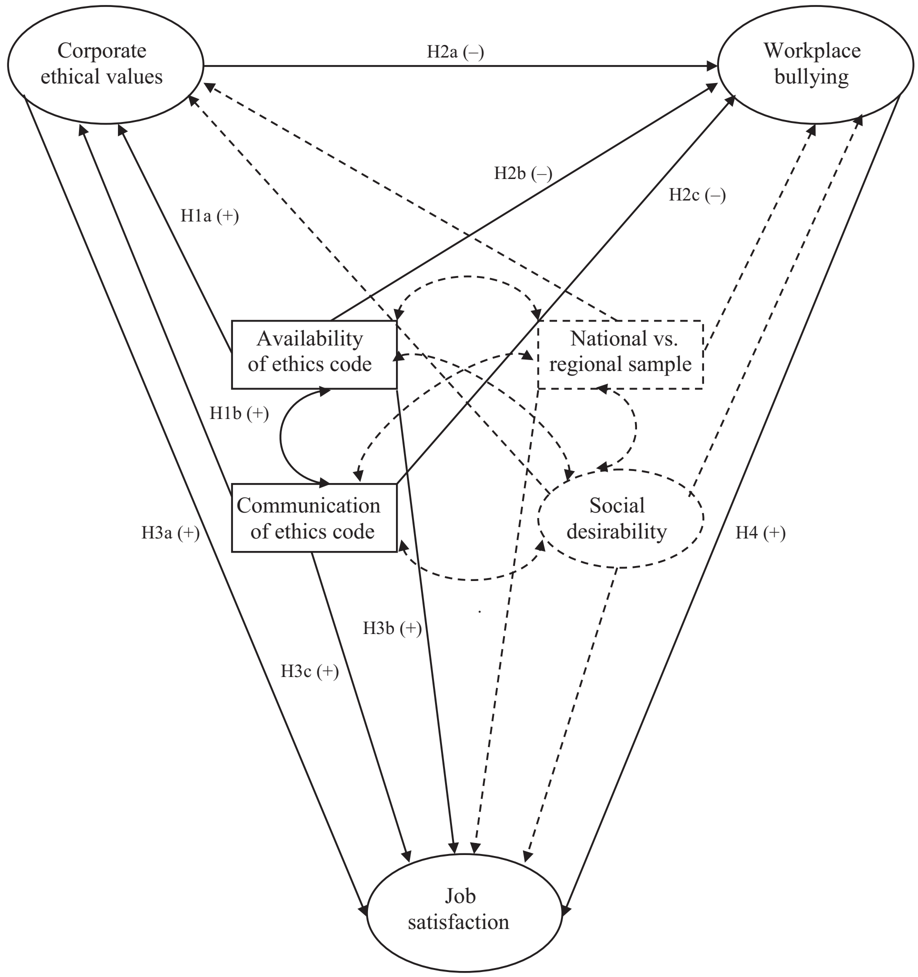

Figure 1. Hypothesized relationships.
Note: Control variables/relationships presented with dotted borders/lines.

that bullying qualifies as systematic, repetitive (Bulutlar and Oz 2009; Zapf and Einarsen 2001), hostile (Bulutlar and Oz 2009), and aggressive behavior (Einarsen 1999). Different thresholds have also been offered in the literature, such as the behavior must occur persistently for some time (e.g., six months; Einarsen et al. 2011; Quine 1999) or occur at least once (Leymann 1996) or twice in a given week (Hershcovis 2011).

Workplace bullying bears a strong resemblance to the deviant behaviors that occur in the sales profession. For instance, a seasoned selling professional might chastise an inexperienced, low-performing colleague who does not identify enough new leads to contact, or a salesperson might retaliate against co-workers who do not share sales contacts by making unkind remarks about them in front of customers and other employees. The work–family conflicts and other pressures associated with selling might also lead individuals to bully others:

> Because of fear of retaliation, salespeople may refrain from directly targeting sales managers or the organization with their deviant behaviors. However, they may displace aggression onto others … This displaced aggression may take the form of mild to severe aggression directed at co-workers such as gossip, name calling, or even physical assault. (Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010, 241)

Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett (2010) identified other deviant behaviors of an interpersonal nature that can occur in selling organizations, including speaking hurtfully to colleagues, stealing sales leads, selling in someone else's sales territory, and withholding customer contact information. Serviere-Munoz and Mallin (2013) also suggested that neutralizations could be used by sales professionals to rationalize retaliation against individuals who wrongfully injure another party. Finally, in-house conflicts over how to serve customers and complete work assignments might exist between sales professionals and support employees, encouraging individuals to use various defensive tactics that can spiral into dysfunctional behavior at work (Tellefsen and Eyuboglu 2002). 'For example, employees may adhere to petty rules, redirect issues, prolong tasks, reduce internal communications, plead ignorance, or misrepresent facts' (161). While the motivations and tactics associated with these different acts may vary, it is likely that workplace bullying is present and underlies these behaviors because there is intent to harm others.

Corporate ethics

In response to the ethical concerns and deviant/bullying behaviors found in the sales profession, there is growing awareness that organizations must develop a work environment that encourages salespeople to think and behave ethically (Ferrell et al. 2007; Wotruba 1990). This often includes investing in various corporate ethics programs such as codes of conduct, ethics communication/training, risk management, ethics officers, reporting approaches, and reinforcement processes (i.e., punishments/rewards) that institutionalize ethical values/culture (e.g., Ferrell, Fraedrich, and Ferrell 2008). Past work shows that these practices can improve decision-making by making employees more aware of different ethical challenges, improving their ability to make ethical judgments, and encouraging them to perform their jobs ethically (e.g., Douglas, Davidson, and Schwartz 2001; Singhapakdi 1993; Singhapakdi and Vitell 1991; Singhapakdi et al. 2000; Valentine and Barnett 2007).

Ethics codes are particularly important when building an ethical work context. Codes are instrumental in helping an organization highlight important behavioral standards and guidelines (Dean 1992). Codes can also be utilized to teach individuals about the company's ethical values/principles (Benson 1989):

> As part of a firm's structure, a written code of ethics – a formal, management-initiated control that sets standards or expectations regarding both preferred and problematic behaviors (Brothers 1991; Weaver 1993) – is perhaps one of the most important influences on the firm's ethical climate. (Ingram, LaForge, and Schwepker 2007, 305)

In particular, both the availability and communication of ethics codes should be considered when attempting to develop corporate ethics.

The presence of ethics codes underscores the commitment of managers to ethical conduct (Ford and Richardson 1994; Wotruba, Chonko, and Loe 2001) and can enhance sales professionals' ethical attitudes (Chonko, Wotruba, and Loe 2002; DeConinck 2003; Schwepker and Good 2007). Research shows that the presence of an ethics code can encourage stronger beliefs among sales professionals (and other employees) that an employer is ethical (Adams, Tashchian, and Shore 2001; Valentine and Barnett 2002, 2003). Wotruba, Chonko, and Loe (2001) also surveyed 286 executives in the direct selling industry, and results showed that individuals believed that code usefulness was based on familiarity and the enhancements to work climate.

Yet, the presence of a code does not necessarily translate into increased familiarity among organizational members (Stevens 1994; Wotruba, Chonko, and Loe 2001). While availability can result in greater individual comprehension (Chonko and Hunt 1985), codes are not impactful on behavior if their content is not actively communicated and widely understood by employees (Weeks and Nantel 1992). Consequently, both the existence and enforcement of ethics codes is likely required for successful implementation (Dubinsky and Levy 1985; Weeks and Nantel 1992; McClaren 2000); awareness stems from exposure through communication and discussion. Codes can be communicated through ethical training (Honeycutt, Abmed, and Mottner 2004; McClaren 2000; Schwepker and Good 2007; Valentine 2009), ethics coaching (Schwepker and Good 2004), and orientations to ethical values and compliance (O'Fallon and Butterfield 2005; Valentine and Johnson 2005). The following hypotheses are therefore specified:

> Hypothesis 1a: The increased availability of ethics codes is associated with stronger perceptions of corporate ethical values among selling professionals.

> Hypothesis 1b: The increased communication of ethics codes is associated with stronger perceptions of corporate ethical values among selling professionals.

Sales organizations should also adopt CEVs and promote ethical practices that deter workplace bullying and deviance. Such a work environment can strengthen selling professionals' ethical resolve and reduce the potential for interpersonal conflict. Indeed, deviant behavior can be the result of a poor work climate caused by destructive employee interactions and negative employment experiences (Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010; Robinson and O'Leary-Kelly 1998), and workplace bullying can be precipitated by job conflicts that have spiraled into dysfunctional behavior (Crawford 1997): 'In a nutshell, bullying is a symptom of organizational dysfunction' (221). Consequently, ethical sales organizations should advance the requisite employment context that supports positive employee practices and interactions, mitigating the tendency for salespeople to bully others at work. Ingram, LaForge, and Schwepker (2007, 305) conceptualized this context as the 'interpersonal dimension of ethical climate,' claiming that the:

> more individuals within the firm inherently care about doing what is right for those both inside and outside the organization and thus act accordingly (i.e., doing what us 'right' is internalized), the more ethical the climate is expected to be perceived.

These notions suggest that corporate ethics is negatively related to workplace bullying.

Bullying can also occur when there are power differences among individuals (e.g., Matthiesen and Einarsen 2001; Mikkelsen and Einarsen 2002) established by supervisory authority (Einarsen, Raknes, and Matthiesen 1994), formal position, social status, age, or job tenure (Hershcovis

2011). Bullies can act inappropriately because they have leverage, and:

> relatively low-ranked employees (such as salespeople) do not have direct access to these traditional forms of power. They have little or no authority. In addition, they do not have access to the resources required to reward or punish other employees. They also, as a group, do not possess any characteristics that make them intrinsically any more or less attractive than any other members of the organization. (Tellefsen and Eyuboglu 2002, 160)

While co-workers sometimes bully others, bullies often function in positions of authority (Van Schalkwyk, Els, and Rothmann 2011). Supervisors are particularly positioned to harm their subordinates and to escalate behaviors into bullying (Vandekerckhove and Commers 2003). The National Business Ethics Survey in 2013 corroborates that managers are responsible for 60% of workplace misconduct (NBES 2013). There is also evidence that individuals victimized by superiors suffer greater psychological harm (Einarsen and Raknes 1997) and other negative effects such as reduced commitment and increased quitting intentions (Koonin and Green 2004; McCormick et al. 2006; Van Schalkwyk, Els, and Rothmann 2011). In ethical firms, managers tend to be keenly invested in the development of ethical values (Ferrell et al. 2007; Ingram, LaForge, and Schwepker 2007; Wotruba 1990), and this interest should dissuade them from bullying others who possess lesser power. Finally, CEVs are often communicated through rewards and sanctions distributed by authority figures, which further encourages employees to follow ethical codes, standards, and guidelines (Ford and Richardson 1994; Ferrell and Skinner 1988; Laczniak and Inderrieden 1987). Consequently, sales organizations should utilize ethical values to manage misbehavior. The National Business Ethics Survey in 2013 supports this assertion by linking a strong ethical culture with a decrease in observed ethical misconduct (NBES 2013).

Similar to ethical values, the ethical climate construct also appears to be an important contextual determinant of workplace bullying. Victor and Cullen (1988) defined ethical work climate as the ‘prevailing perceptions of typical organizational practices and procedures that have ethical content’ (101). The variable is an integral part of organizational culture, and selling organizations can establish unique subcultures or ethical climates within different work groups (Ferrell et al. 2007). Ethical climate can also shape employee behavior (Wotruba, Chonko, and Loe 2001), which suggests that workplace bullying and other misbehavior is precipitated when employees work under a poor ethical climate. Bulutlar and Oz (2009) reported a positive association between bullying and egoistic climates and instrumental climates. Alternatively, negative associations have been found between bullying and the presence of principled, rules, caring, and law and code climates. Finally, Vardi (2001) reported a negative relationship between benevolent/caring climates and misconduct.

Codes of conduct are also widely used to enhance individual ethics (Ingram, LaForge, and Schwepker 2007). In particular, interest in the creation, dissemination, and implementation of ethics codes has increased within different fields (Cadogan et al. 2009; DeConinck 2003; Roman and Munuera 2005; Schwepker 2001; Valentine and Fleischman 2008), including the sales profession (Ingram, LaForge, and Schwepker 2007; McClaren 2000, 2013; Valentine and Barnett 2002, 2003). This interest is driven by the awareness that ethics codes, when effectively written in a manner that highlights important ethical issues/challenges, can provide decision-making guidelines for employees. As such, codes have the capacity to encourage ethical conduct (Ford and Richardson 1994; Levy and Dubinsky 1983; Weeks and Nantel 1992).

The relationship between codes of ethics and individual ethical decision-making is also explored in past research. In one review of the literature, Ford and Richardson (1994) concluded that such codes influence ethical reasoning. Loe, Ferrell, and Mansfield (2000) isolated 10 related studies in the literature, and seven supported the notion that ethics codes contribute to ethical reasoning. A later review conducted by O’Fallon and Butterfield (2005) evaluated 20 papers, and most supported a positive relationship between the two variables. Additionally, sales employees’ perceptions of ethical issues should be more focused where codes of conduct are in place (Singhapakdi and Vitell 1991), particularly where managers facilitate internalization of corporate values by employees (DeConinck and Lewis 1997; Hunt and Vasquez-Parraga 1993). The following hypotheses are therefore presented:

> Hypothesis 2a: Increased perceptions of corporate ethical values are associated with weaker perceptions of workplace bullying among selling professionals.

> Hypothesis 2b: The increased availability of ethics codes is associated with weaker perceptions of workplace bullying among selling professionals.

> Hypothesis 2c: The increased communication of ethics codes is associated with weaker perceptions of workplace bullying among selling professionals.

Job satisfaction

Job satisfaction involves ‘a pleasurable or positive emotional state resulting from the appraisal of one’s job experiences’ (Locke 1976, 1300). Since job satisfaction is central to positive management (it functions as both an outcome and predictor variable), the construct is investigated extensively in the organizational sciences (Vlachos, Panagopoulos, and Rapp 2013), and particularly in the sales literature (e.g., Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010; Valentine 2009). As a whole, when individuals perceive their experiences at work are positive over time (Hausknecht, Sturman, and Roberson 2011), job satisfaction is often the resulting work outcome (Locke 1969). Given this enduring relationships, as well as desirability of employment in organizations that emphasize ethics and social responsibility, there is often a consistent relationship identified between corporate ethics and job satisfaction. In particular, sales and marketing professionals show a preference for ethical workplace conduct (Valentine 2009), and salespersons often want more management guidance regarding ethical issues than what is commonly available (Dubinsky et al. 1992). As a result, strong preferences for corporate ethics among sales professionals should increase job satisfaction when such an environment is provided by an employer.

Several conceptual frameworks can be used to show that corporate ethics positively impacts job satisfaction. For instance, cumulative experiences related to workplace justice, a variable that is reflective of organizational ethics, are linked to corresponding variations in job satisfaction (Hausknecht, Sturman, and Roberson 2011). Equity theory (Adams 1963) uses the process of perceived fairness, also embedded within the domain of organizational ethics, to better understand employee satisfaction and motivation. The theory suggests that individuals compare the ratio of personal inputs into work (i.e., effort, knowledge, and skills) with the outcomes received from inputs (i.e., pay, benefits, and intrinsic rewards). These assessments are then compared to evaluations of the input/outcome ratios of other employees. When an imbalance is perceived, individuals experience dissatisfaction and will be motivated to establish parity. Ethical organizations are often more concerned with fairness issues, making them keenly positioned to effectively manage employee job satisfaction. Finally, dissonance theory suggests that ethical organizations should be better positioned to enhance individual job satisfaction because employees perceive less conflict when they work for a company that has an ethical workplace (Viswesvaran and Deshpande 1996; Viswesvaran, Deshpande, and Joseph 1998). Consequently, increased job satisfaction among salespersons should be an indication that their employer has developed an ethical culture/climate.

Empirical research supports these claims. For instance, Schwepker (2001) concluded that salespersons' perceptions of a positive ethical climate (based on ethics codes, ethics policies, and managerial ethics) were associated with increased job satisfaction and organizational commitment. Valentine (2009) using a sample of sales and marketing professionals determined that ethics training and organizational ethics were related to individuals' satisfaction with supervisors and co-workers. Viswesvaran and Deshpande (1996) and Viswesvaran, Deshpande, and Joseph (1998) determined that perceptions of managerial ethics were positively related to different measures of job satisfaction in two separate investigations of Indian managers. Ruiz-Palomino, Martinez-Canas, and Fontrodona (2012) found that stronger perceived indicators of ethical culture were positively related to job satisfaction (and other positive work outcomes) based on information collected from banking professionals working in Spain. Vitell and Davis (1990) using a sample of MIS professionals also determined that management support of ethics was also positively associated with various measures of job satisfaction. A study involving 438 employees from three world-leading manufacturers found respondents who viewed their leaders as charismatic tended to attribute their organization's motives for engaging in CSR due to intrinsic values and experienced greater job satisfaction (Vlachos, Panagopoulos, and Rapp 2013). Finally, Valentine, Greller, and Richtermeyer (2006) collected data from a large sample of accountants and determined that perceptions of CEVs were related to job satisfaction, as well as perceived organization support and turnover intentions. The following hypotheses are therefore offered:

> Hypothesis 3a: Increased perceptions of corporate ethical values are associated with higher job satisfaction among selling professionals.
>
> Hypothesis 3b: The increased availability of ethics codes is associated with higher job satisfaction among selling professionals.
>
> Hypothesis 3c: The increased communication of ethics codes is associated with higher job satisfaction among selling professionals.

Workplace bullying should also be consistently and negatively related to job satisfaction. Since bullying affects victims psychologically, its impact can be described in terms of cognition and other mental responses (Nielsen and Einarsen 2012). Negative reactions to bullying can occur because there are discrepancies between persons' expectations about how they should be treated at work and the experiences they actually endure. The cognitive incongruity that occurs can encourage health problems (Mikkelsen and Einarsen 2002; Nielsen, Matthiesen, and Einarsen 2008) and long-term, negative affective/attitudinal responses (Nielsen and Einarsen 2012). Work burnout (Einarsen and Skogstad 1998) and post-traumatic stress disorder (Leymann and Gustafsson 1996; Matthiesen and Einarsen 2001) are other eventual negative responses (Nielsen and Einarsen 2012). Consequently, both psychological (Einarsen and Raknes 1997) and physical health (Mikkelsen and Einarsen 2002; Nielsen, Matthiesen, and Einarsen 2008) problems can adversely impact individuals who are bullied on the job.

The cumulative effects of bullying that occur over time can be particularly challenging (Leymann 1996;

Nielsen and Einarsen 2012) because individual/job-related well-being and work performance can be affected (Devonish 2013; Einarsen and Mikkelsen 2003; Kivmäki, Elovainio, and Vahtera 2000; Neuman and Baron 2011; Rodríguez-Muñoz et al. 2009). Bullying can cause severe job stress and is viewed as a significant social stressor (Einarsen and Mikkelsen 2003; Rodríguez-Muñoz et al. 2009; Zapf, Knorz, and Kulla 1996). Stress is an occupational challenge that negatively impacts employees physically, behaviorally, and mentally (Nielsen and Einarsen 2012), including poor health, decreased work performance, and less favorable work attitudes. Job stress can indeed lead to reduced job satisfaction (Adebayo and Ogunsina 2011; Bowling and Beehr 2006; Hollon and Chesser 1976; Quine 2001; Rodríguez-Muñoz et al. 2009; Spector 1997).

Previous research indicates that workplace bullying can directly influence different work attitudes. For example, a recent meta-analysis determined that bullying is negatively associated with organizational commitment (Bowling and Beehr 2006), and another study found that bullying is negatively related to affective commitment (McCormick et al. 2006). Bullying can also result in decreased job satisfaction (Adebayo and Ogunsina 2011; Bowling and Beehr 2006; Quine 2001; Rodríguez-Muñoz et al. 2009). Devonish (2013) found that job satisfaction, work-related depression, and psychological well-being mediated the link between workplace bullying and work performance, conceptualized to include organizational citizenship behavior, counterproductive work behavior, and task performance. Meta-analytic findings (Nielsen and Einarsen 2012) suggest a relationship between bullying and reductions in job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and mental health. Sims and Sun (2012) found a negative relationship between workplace bullying and employee satisfaction and organizational commitment. Relationships have been found between victimization and decreased job satisfaction (Rodríguez-Muñoz et al. 2009).

Workplace bullying is also a predictor of turnover (Begley 1998; Berthelsen et al. 2011; Djurkovic, McCormack, and Casimir 2004; Van Schalkwyk, Els, and Rothmann 2011). It has been estimated that as many as one in four of individuals who experience such mistreatment will seek employment elsewhere (Rasool et al. 2013). For example, turnover intent has been found among nurses victimized by bullying (Quine 2001). A study of 350 Nigerian police found a significant relationship between negative supervisory behavior and turnover intent (Adebayo and Ogunsina 2011). Finally, abusive supervision (Tepper 2000), which involves the 'sustained display of hostile verbal and non-verbal behaviors, excluding physical contact' (178), appears to negatively affect commitment, organizational citizenship behavior, and quitting intentions (McCormick et al. 2006; Hershcovis 2011; Zellars, Tepper, and Duffy 2002). The following hypothesis is therefore specified:

> Hypothesis 4: Increased perceptions of workplace bullying are associated with lower job satisfaction among selling professionals.

Importance and rationale of the study

This study is important because the self-interest and competitive boundary spanning found in the sales profession might invite workplace bullying. Selling professionals may choose to bully others because they function in a work environment that is inherently unethical. Since there are no published investigations of workplace bullying in the sales profession, this study seeks to underscore how organizational ethics might be used to curtail workplace bullying among selling professionals. Such examination is also relevant given the many ethics challenges that sales personnel must negotiate (e.g., Caywood and Laczniak 1986; McClaren 2000, 2013; Wotruba 1990). The tendency for individuals to lie, mislead, and act in other deviant ways could lead salespersons to use workplace bullying as a way to cope with job pressures and conflicts. The boundary-spanning and autonomous nature of their work makes workplace bullying within sales organizations particularly troubling because management may not be aware of the behavior, or even worse, they might be aware but are unwilling to correct the situation, particularly if the bully is a high performer. Sales managers may choose not to seriously reprimand successful sales professionals who behave inappropriately (Bellizzi and Hasty 2003).

This underscores the potential role of organizational ethics as an effective mechanism for managing workplace bullying, and this study is the first to consider the proposed linkages among corporate ethics (both codes and ethical values), workplace bullying, and job satisfaction in the selling environment. Examination of these factors is important because the findings could suggest that sales leadership can create an ethical context that discourages workplace bullying by taking away the environmental triggers that prompt salespersons to mistreat others and hurt job satisfaction. Positive ethical values and other ethical practices could be used strategically to advance a selling environment that dissuades individuals from harming co-workers. In sum, the study's theoretical insight is that bullying is a new concern in sales organizations, representing a subset of deviant behavior as a whole. As such, examination of such misconduct represents a potential area of important and interesting inquiry that fills a gap in the sales ethics literature.

Method

Data

Data were collected from a national sample of 3000 selling professionals whose contact information was available from a third-party commercial provider. A questionnaire, which was reviewed extensively by two prominent ethics scholars before the collection of data, was used to obtain information about individuals' work experiences and attitudes. An envelope containing a cover letter, questionnaire, and a postage-paid return envelope was mailed to individuals, and this first wave yielded 95 questionnaires. Roughly three months later, a second wave of materials was sent, which resulted in 43 questionnaires. These two waves resulted in a total of 138 questionnaires and an overall approximate response rate was 4.73% after ineligible questionnaires were considered.

Given that the initial sample size was modest, information was also obtained from a convenience sample of selling professionals employed in different companies located in the southern USA.[1] A coordinating individual provided professionals copies of the questionnaire, and additional forms were sometimes provided so that more individuals could be recruited to participate in the survey. Completed forms were given directly to the coordinating researcher, or the questionnaires were submitted to another contact individual who forwarded them. An additional 246 questionnaires were collected as a result of these efforts, which generated an overall total of 384 questionnaires. A total of 28 questionnaires were taken out of the sample because the individuals appeared not to be involved in any selling activities.[2] Based on this assessment, a total usable sample of 356 questionnaires was secured.

The selling professionals had an average age of nearly 39 years, and over half of individuals were male (59.9%), white (70%), and married (53%). Individuals were moderately educated with 51% having some college and 22.2% having a bachelor's degree. Responses to work-related items indicated that 80.1% were currently working full-time with an average of 8.16 years of job tenure, and 42.9% were sales/marketing managers, 9.8% were general managers, and 30.8% worked in 'other' jobs. With regard to selling information, professionals' average selling experience was 13.82 years (based on 353 responses), average sales calls per day (in their current jobs) was 9.32 (based on 310 responses), average hours spent per week on selling activities was 27.05 (based on 339 responses), and average sales accounts called on per week was 249.57 (based on 275 responses). Other demographic items showed that close to half (44.5%) of firms represented functioned in the wholesale/retail industry, while a respective 15.9% and 9.6% functioned in the manufacturing/construction and services sectors. More than half of firms represented had fewer than 100 employees, 28% had 100–1000 employees, and 20.5% had more than 1000 employees.

Measures

Several scales were used in this investigation to evaluate the focal variables, and many of these measures appear in previous research. The following sections describe the scales.

Availability and communication of an ethics code

The ethics codes variables were evaluated with single-item measures that tapped the presence and discussion of codified ethical guidelines within the selling professionals' organizations: The single item for the availability of a code was 'Does your organization have an ethics code that governs work conduct? (1) No (2) Yes (if "Yes," answer the next questions).' The single item for the communication of a code was 'Does your organization communicate this ethics code to employees? (1) No, not at all (2) Somewhat (3) Yes, frequently.'

Corporate ethical values

A 5-item CEV scale was utilized to evaluate selling professionals' perceptions of organizational ethics (Hunt, Wood, and Chonko 1989). This scale has been utilized in many studies of sales ethics and is viewed as an exceptional tool for the measurement of the ethical values in companies (Valentine and Barnett 2002, 2007; Valentine et al. 2011). The scale assesses leadership involvement in the development of ethics, reinforcement of ethical practices, and the prevalence of ethical behavior in a workplace, which makes it particularly well-suited for investigations of workplace bullying. Responses were provided on a 7-point scale anchored by 1 (strongly disagree) and 7 (strongly agree), and two items were coded in reverse. Higher item values indicted stronger perceptions of CEV.

Workplace bullying

Selling professionals' perceptions of workplace bullying were assessed with the 5-item Bergen Bullying Index (Einarsen, Raknes, and Matthiesen 1994), which 'is a global measurement of potential individual and organizational consequences of bullying and harassment' (387). The scale shows particular high internal consistency reliability with previous coefficient alpha scores of .86 (Einarsen et al. 1994) and .82 (Matthiesen and Einarsen 2007). Individuals were asked to indicate the degree to which bullying was a serious problem in their place of work, and while responses are traditionally provided on a 4-point scale comprised of 'agree strongly' and 'disagree strongly,' responses in this study were provided on a 7-point scale anchored with 1 (strongly disagree) and

7 (strongly agree). Higher scores suggested increased problems related to workplace bullying.

Job satisfaction

Selling professionals' satisfaction with their current jobs was assessed with a 3-item global scale (Cammann et al. 1983; Rich 1997). Others studies have effectively used these items, and findings show that the measure has high internal consistency reliability with coefficient alphas scores above .80 (Rich 1997; Valentine and Fleischman 2008; Valentine et al. 2011; Valentine et al. 2010). Opinions were provided on a 7-point scale comprised of 1 (strongly disagree) and 7 (strongly agree), and one item was reverse-coded. Higher item values indicated increased job satisfaction among the selling professionals.

Social desirability

A shortened, 10-item version of the Marlowe–Crowne social desirability scale was used to assess selling professionals' tendency toward impression management (Crowne and Marlowe 1960; Fischer and Fick 1993; Strahan and Gerbasi 1972), a tendency known to confound ethics research (Randall and Fernandes 1991). Items were rated with a 7-point scale comprised of 1 (strongly disagree) and 7 (strongly agree), and five items were reverse-scored so that higher values indicated more profound individual social desirability. Based on the results of several principal components factor and reliability analyses, two items were selected to represent the construct. The findings indicated that the two items had loadings of .90 and generated an eigenvalue of 1.61, and the model explained 80.33% of the variance. The two-item measure was specified as a control variable in the analysis.

Analysis

Comparisons across the data collection rounds were initially made to determine whether nonresponse bias was an issue in this study based on survey differences between early and late responders (see Armstrong and Overton 1977), as well as to isolate any differences between the national and regional samples. Structural equation modeling was utilized to assess the proposed relationships (AMOS 6.0). Evaluation and revision of the measurement model was performed with a confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) based on a multi-step modification approach (Anderson and Gerbing 1988). Maximum likelihood estimation was utilized, and one estimate for each unobserved construct was set to a value of '1' (Arbuckle and Wothke 1999). Composite reliability estimates and variance extracted scores were also calculated using the standardized parameters associated with each of the observed items (Hair et al. 1998). Once a set of finalized items was identified, item values were then added together and divided by the total number of items in a particular scale to develop composite scores, which were evaluated (SPSS 12.0) with descriptive statistics, correlations (utilizing pairwise deletion), and coefficient alphas. Finally, a structural framework containing both measurement and structural models was specified for the purposes of hypothesis testing.

Results

Variable comparisons across data collection (sampling) rounds

Table 1 provides an overview of the variable differences across the two waves of the national sample, as well as comparisons between the national and regional samples. Significant response differences across the two waves (early versus late responders) were not identified for the national sample based on analysis of variance results, cross tabulations, and chi-square statistics, which suggested that nonresponse bias was likely not present. However, there were many variable differences between the national and the regional samples, providing support for the idea that the regional sample enhanced the study's external validity. For example, significant differences ($p < .001$) were identified for age, gender, education, job tenure, selling experience, CEV, job satisfaction, and social desirability, among others. Because of these differences, a sampling control variable was included in the analysis.

Initial CFA

As shown in Table 2, the results of the initial CFA showed that model fit was adequate, but that it could be improved (Arbuckle and Wothke 1999; Hu and Bentler 1999). The items were related to the unobserved factors ($p < .001$), which suggested that there was adequate convergent validity (see Table 3). All but two of the items related to the CEV measure had standardized estimates greater than .50, and the covariances/correlations indicated that the unobserved variables were interrelated. Composite reliability and variance extracted scores were calculated for each of the latent factors using the standardized parameter estimates for each of the items (Bagozzi and Yi 1988; Hair et al. 1998). These calculations produced acceptable scores for most of the focal variables, but the variance extracted statistic for CEV was slightly below what is considered to be acceptable.

The two CEV items were taken out of the model, and a revised CFA was specified. The fit statistics for this second model were much improved (see Table 2), and items were once again related to the observed variables ($p < .001$) with standardized estimates above .50 (see Table 4). Consequently, the measurement model required no further revisions. The composite reliability scores for CEV, workplace bullying, job satisfaction, and social desirability were all acceptable. The variance-extracted estimates for each of the focal variables were higher than the squared correlations for

Table 1. Variable comparisons across data collection (sampling) rounds.

Dependent variable	Survey response	*M*	SD	*n*	*F*	Sample	*M*	SD	*n*	*F*
Age in years	Early responders	49.77	11.48	90	.01	National	49.71	11.12	127	144.18***
	Late responders	49.57	10.33	37		Regional	32.46	13.76	216	
Gender[a]	Early responders	1.20	.40	92	.15	National	1.20	.41	132	37.23***
	Late responders	1.23	.42	40		Regional	1.52	.50	222	
Education[b]	Early responders	2.78	1.02	91	1.44	National	2.85	1.07	130	56.74***
	Late responders	3.03	1.18	39		Regional	2.08	.84	221	
Years of job tenure	Early responders	14.45	10.85	91	.29	National	14.12	10.58	131	115.69***
	Late responders	13.38	10.05	40		Regional	4.55	5.99	216	
Years of selling experience	Early responders	22.10	11.53	92	.10	National	22.31	11.31	132	147.60***
	Late responders	22.78	10.93	40		Regional	8.75	9.38	221	
Sales calls per day	Early responders	6.48	11.04	81	.64	National	6.99	10.51	115	1.78
	Late responders	8.21	9.16	34		Regional	10.69	28.59	195	
Hours per week selling	Early responders	25.51	15.92	88	1.82	National	26.74	15.60	126	.09
	Late responders	29.58	14.64	38		Regional	27.24	14.61	213	
Sales accounts called per week	Early responders	467.44	1435.50	80	.90	National	397.72	1255.96	110	4.21*
	Late responders	211.80	516.06	30		Regional	150.81	736.59	165	
Organization size[c]	Early responders	1.59	.73	92	.01	National	1.58	.74	132	3.82
	Late responders	1.58	.78	40		Regional	1.75	.81	215	
Availability of ethics code	Early responders	1.62	.49	89	.12	National	1.63	.49	129	7.15**
	Late responders	1.65	.48	40		Regional	1.76	.43	218	
Communication of ethics code	Early responders	2.25	.75	67	.46	National	2.29	.76	100	1.15
	Late responders	2.36	.78	33		Regional	2.38	.63	173	
Corporate ethical values	Early responders	5.52	1.67	91	.48	National	5.45	1.72	130	13.09***
	Late responders	5.29	1.85	39		Regional	4.80	1.56	221	
Workplace bullying	Early responders	2.68	1.78	87	.85	National	2.58	1.79	125	3.47
	Late responders	2.36	1.81	38		Regional	2.97	1.92	220	
Job satisfaction	Early responders	5.86	1.39	91	2.77	National	5.72	1.50	130	16.11***
	Late responders	5.38	1.71	39		Regional	5.03	1.56	221	
Social desirability	Early responders	6.07	1.19	92	1.38	National	5.99	1.23	131	16.96***
	Late responders	5.79	1.30	39		Regional	5.37	1.45	223	

*$p < .05$; **$p < .01$; ***$p < .001$.
[a]1 = male, 2 = female, [b]1 = High school diploma, 2 = Some college, 3 = Bachelor's degree, 4 = Some graduate work, 5 = Graduate degree, [c]1 = Fewer than 100, 2 = 100 to 1000, 3 = Greater than 1000.
Cross-tabulations and χ^2 statistics calculated to determine differences across marital status, race, full-/part-time/temp status, job classification, and organization industry; no differences were found across early/late responders; differences were found between national/regional samples ($p < .001$).

the associated variable pairs, which showed adequate discriminant validity (Fornell and Larcker 1981). A single-factor test was conducted to check for the presence of common method bias (Podsakoff et al. 2003), and findings showed that the one-factor model did not exhibit sound fit (see Table 2), suggesting that bias was likely not a problem given the numerous default models displayed.

Variable descriptive statistics, correlations, and reliability estimates

The variable descriptive statistics, correlations, and reliability statistics are summarized in Table 5. The mean values for the ethics code variables indicated that a majority of companies had a code of conduct, and that codes were communicated relatively frequently in

Table 2. Model fit statistics.

Model	χ^2	*df*	*p*	χ^2/df	RMSEA	NFI	IFI	CFI
Initial confirmatory factor analysis	365.925	84	.000	4.356	.097	.873	.899	.898
Revised confirmatory factor analysis	234.324	59	.000	3.972	.091	.911	.932	.931
Single-factor test	1695.883	65	.000	26.091	.266	.357	.367	.360
Structural model	274.004	86	.000	3.186	.078	.905	.933	.931

Notes: Default models reported; χ^2/df, relative chi-square; RMSEA, root mean square error of approx.; NFI, normed fit index; IFI, incremental fit index; CFI, comparative fit index; $N = 356$.

Table 3. Results of initial confirmatory factor analysis.

Variable(s) Item(s)	Composite reliability	Variance extracted	Parameter estimate	Standardized estimate
Measurement model				
Corporate ethical values	.78	.44		
Managers in my organization often engage in behaviors that I consider to be unethical. (R)			.57***	.44
In order to succeed in my organization, it is often necessary to compromise one'sethics. (R)			.51***	.42
Top management in my company has let it be known in no uncertain terms that unethical behaviors will not be tolerated			.93***	.70
If a manager in my company is discovered to have engaged in unethical behavior that results primarily in personal gain (rather than corporate gain), he or she will be promptly reprimanded			1.05***	.84
If a manager in my company is discovered to have engaged in unethical behavior that results primarily in corporate gain (rather than personal gain), he or she will be promptly reprimanded			1.00	.79
Workplace bullying	.88	.61		
Bullying is a serious strain in my daily work			.52***	.55
Bullying at my workplace reduces our efficiency			1.09***	.90
Bullying at my workplace reduces my well-being			1.13***	.95
Bullying is a serious problem at my workplace			.45***	.53
Bullying at my workplace reduces my work motivation			1.00***	.87
Job satisfaction	.87	.69		
All in all, I am satisfied with my job			1.47***	.93
In general, I like working at my company			1.38***	.89
In general, I don't like my job. (R)			1.00***	.87
Social desirability	.76	.61		
I'm always willing to admit it when I make a mistake			1.29***	.81
I always try to practice what I preach			1.00	.75
			(Covariances)	(Correlations)
Corporate ethical values ←→ Job Satisfaction			.87***	.52
Social desirability ←→ Workplace bullying			.40**	.18
Workplace bullying ←→ Job satisfaction			−.42**	−.18
Corporate ethical values ←→ Workplace bullying			−.33	−.10
Social desirability ←→ Job satisfaction			.48***	.40
Social desirability ←→ Corporate ethical values			.58***	.37

(R), reverse coded.
$^{**}p < .01$; $^{***}p < .001$, $N = 356$.

companies that had such documents. The mean value for CEV suggested that the selling professionals believed that their organizations had ethical values, and the mean value for workplace bullying suggested that misconduct occurred moderately in the organizations represented in the data. Although the bullying mean value was lower than the means for the other focal variables, this does not render bullying unimportant. The mean value for job satisfaction indicated that individuals were generally satisfied with their work situations. The mean values for the sampling and social desirability control variables showed that the regional sample was larger than the national sample, and that selling professionals' tendencies toward impression management were modest.

The correlations indicated that the availability of an ethics code was positively related to both the communication of an ethics code ($p < .001$) and CEV ($p < .001$), and that code communication was positively related to CEV ($p < .001$) and job satisfaction ($p < .05$). CEV was negatively related to workplace bullying ($p < .05$) and positively related to job satisfaction ($p < .001$), while workplace bullying was negatively related to job satisfaction ($p < .001$). As a whole, these correlations provided early support for the study's hypotheses. The sampling variable was related to ethics code availability, CEV, job satisfaction, and social desirability, while CEV, workplace bullying, and job satisfaction were associated with the measure of social desirability. These results further support the idea that these variables should be specified as controls in the analysis. The coefficient alphas were also above a value of .70, indicating that the scales had high internal consistency reliability.

Table 4. Results of revised confirmatory factor analysis.

Variable(s) Item(s)	Composite reliability	Variance extracted	Parameter estimate	Standardized estimate
Measurement Model				
Corporate ethical values	.83	.62		
Top management in my company has let it be known in no uncertain terms that unethical behaviors will not be tolerated			.92***	.69
If a manager in my company is discovered to have engaged in unethical behavior that results primarily in personal gain (rather than corporate gain), he or she will be promptly reprimanded			1.11***	.88
If a manager in my company is discovered to have engaged in unethical behavior that results primarily in corporate gain (rather than personal gain), he or she will be promptly reprimanded			1.00***	.78
Workplace bullying	.88	.61		
Bullying is a serious strain in my daily work			.52***	.55
Bullying at my workplace reduces our efficiency			1.09***	.90
Bullying at my workplace reduces my well-being			1.13***	.95
Bullying is a serious problem at my workplace			.45***	.53
Bullying at my workplace reduces my work motivation			1.00	.87
Job satisfaction	.87	.69		
All in all, I am satisfied with my job			1.48***	.93
In general, I like working at my company			1.38***	.89
In general, I don't like my job. (R)			1.00	.64
Social esirability	.76	.61		
I'm always willing to admit it when I make a mistake			1.27***	.81
I always try to practice what I preach			1.00	.64
			(Covariances)	(Correlations)
Corporate ethical values ←→ Job Satisfaction			.87***	.52
Social desirability ←→ Workplace bullying			.40**	.18
Workplace Bullying ←→ Job satisfaction			−.42	−.18
Corporate ethical values ←→ Workplace bullying			−.33	−.10
Social desirability ←→ Job satisfaction			.48***	.40
Social desirability ←→ Corporate ethical values			.58***	.37

(R), reverse coded.
$^{**}p < .01$; $^{***}p < .001$, $N = 356$.

Structural model

The findings related to the structural model are summarized in Table 6 (measurement model results are also shown). The model had acceptable fit statistics (see Table 2), and the observed items were highly related to the latent variables ($p < .001$). The composite reliability and variance extracted scores were once again acceptable. While the relationship between ethics code availability and communication was highly significant, others involving code availability were not (Hypothesis 1a, Hypothesis 2b, and Hypothesis 3b were not supported). The communication of an ethics code and CEV were

Table 5. Variable descriptive statistics, correlations, and reliability statistics.

Variable	*M*	SD	*N*	*α*	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1. Availability of ethics code	1.71	.45	347	–	–						
2. Communication of ethics code	2.35	.68	273	–	.58***	–					
3. Corporate ethical values	5.04	1.65	351	.82	.22***	.36***	–				
4. Workplace bullying	2.83	1.88	345	.89	−.08	−.05	−.13*	–			
5. Job satisfaction	5.29	1.57	351	.86	.10	.12*	.47***	−.23***	–		
6. National vs. Regional samples	1.63	.48	356	–	.14**	.06	−.19***	.10*	−.21***	–	
7. Social desirability	5.60	1.40	354	.75	.03	.04	.32***	.12	.30***	−.21***	–

$^{*}p < .05$; $^{***}p < .001$.

Table 6. Results of structural model.

Variable(s) Item(s)	Composite reliability	Variance estimate	Parameter estimate	Standardized estimate
Measurement model				
Corporate ethical values	.83	.62		
Top management in my company has let it be known in no uncertain terms that unethical behaviors will not be tolerated			.94***	.71
If a manager in my company is discovered to have engaged in unethical behavior that results primarily in personal gain (rather than corporate gain), he or she will be promptly reprimanded			1.10***	87
If a manager in my company is discovered to have engaged in unethical behavior that results primarily in corporate gain (rather than personal gain), he or she will be promptly reprimanded			1.10	.78
Workplace bullying	.88	.61		
Bullying is a serious strain in my daily work			.52***	.56
Bullying at my workplace reduces our efficiency			1.09***	.90
Bullying at my workplace reduces my well-being			1.13***	.95
Bullying is a serious problem at my workplace			.45***	.53
Bullying at my workplace reduces my work motivation			1.00	.87
Job satisfaction	.87	.69		
All in all, I am satisfied with my job.			1.47***	.93
In general, I like working at my company.			1.38***	.89
In general, I don't like my job. (R)			1.00	.64
Social desirability	.76	.61		
I'm always willing to admit it when I make a mistake			1.31***	.82
I always try to practice what I preach			1.00	.74
Structural model				
Availability of ethics code → Corporate ethical values		(H1a)	−.17	−.05
Communication of ethics code → Corporate ethical values		(H1b)	.77***	.41
Corporate ethical values → Workplace bullying		(H2a)	−.28**	−.20
Availability of ethics code → Workplace bullying		(H2b)	−.54	−.12
Communication of ethics code → Workplace		(H2c)	.28	.10
Corporate ethical values → Job satisfaction		(H3a)	.32***	.41
Availability of ethics code → Job satisfaction		(H3b)	.09	.04
Communication of ethics code → Job satisfaction		(H4)	−.11	−.08
Workplace bullying → Job satisfaction			−.10***	−.18
National vs. Regional samples → Corporate ethical values			−.47**	−.15
Social Desirability → Corporate Ethical Values			.42***	.30
National vs. Regional Samples → Workplace Bullying			43	.10
Social desirability → Workplace bullying			.54***	.28
National vs. Regional samples → Job satisfaction			−.12	−.05
Social desirability → Job satisfaction			.28	.27
			(Covariances)	(Correlations)
National vs. Regional samples ←→ Availability of ethics code			.03**	.14
Communication of ethics code ←→ Social desirability			.06	.08
Availability of ethics code ←→ Communication of ethics code			.25***	.71
Availability of ethics code ←→ Social desirability			.02	.04
National vs. Regional samples ←→ Communication of ethics code			.03	.07
National vs. Regional samples←→ Social desirability			−.13***	−.25

(R), reverse coded; measurement model results also shown.
*p < .05; **p < .01; ***p < .001, N = 356.

positively related ($p < .001$), providing support for Hypothesis 1b and suggesting that extensive discussion of codes serves to strengthen an organization's ethical context. CEV was negatively related to workplace bullying ($p < .01$), which supported Hypothesis 2a and indicated that an ethical work environment can be used to mitigate bullying in companies. CEV was positively related to job satisfaction ($p < .001$) and workplace bullying was negatively related to job satisfaction, and these findings supported Hypotheses 3a and 4 and implied that the overall work context exerts considerable influence on employee work attitudes. The sampling control variable was negatively related to CEV ($p < .01$), while social desirability was positively related to CEV, workplace bullying, and job satisfaction ($p < .001$). The relationships associated with social desirability were likely driven by the sensitive nature of the issues investigated.

Discussion and implications

Summary of findings

Several key hypotheses were supported in this study. For example, Hypothesis 1b was supported, which specified a positive association between the communication of an ethics code and CEV. In addition, Hypothesis 2a was supported, which postulated that CEV was negatively associated with bullying experiences. Hypothesis 3a was also sustained, which predicted that CEV was positively associated with job satisfaction. Finally, Hypothesis 4 was supported, which predicted a negative association between job satisfaction and bullying experiences.

Several tertiary hypotheses were not supported. The hypotheses related to the availability of the ethics code were not supported. More specifically, associations between ethics code availability and CEV (Hypothesis 1a), bullying experiences (Hypothesis 2b), and job satisfaction (Hypothesis 3b) were not significant. Related hypotheses pertaining to ethics code communication were not significant regarding workplace bullying (Hypothesis 2b) and job satisfaction (Hypothesis 3b). Surprisingly, the only significant codes-related hypothesized relationship was the positive association between code communication and CEV. This finding provides support for the notion that the availability of ethics codes is a *necessary* condition for development of an ethical environment, but that it is not necessarily a *sufficient* condition to foster such a context. Our conjecture is that the mere availability of ethics codes may serve in certain instances as 'window dressing.' In order for codes to be institutionalized within the ethical context, they should be communicated in conjunction with ethics training programs. Codes should therefore be effectively communicated to employees to enhance organizational ethical values and practices.

Codes of ethics

Although our findings related to the availability of an ethics code were insignificant, the literature suggests codes are necessary in order to increase ethical awareness among members of the sales force (McClaren 2013; Valentine and Barnett 2002, 2003). Therefore, the presence of codes is essential, but the effective communication of codes to employees is also vital to further bolster the ethical context. Based on the current findings, codes should clearly state a *zero tolerance* policy toward bullying. Sales managers need to communicate these guidelines and enforce them vigilantly with disciplinary action when necessary.

There is still not much known about the relationship between ethics codes, corporate ethics programs, and sales ethics. This begs the question: 'What other activities and code communication programs are needed in sales organizations to effectively instill a commitment to ethical behavior?' Furthermore, what specific training programs will most effectively impart the ideals of ethics codes to selling professionals? The need for pertinent code communication strategies may be best effectuated using role-playing training exercises and ethics vignettes that mimic realistic dilemmas that selling professionals routinely experience. It is important that salespeople be trained to recognize the dilemmas they will likely experience in their unique boundary-spanning autonomous jobs, as they are compelled to balance ethical conduct with the stress of meeting sales quotas and benchmarks. To be effective, training should be ongoing, occur at least annually, and consider elements of ethics documentation in the Federal Sentencing Guidelines. Training, role playing, and workshop discussions should provide pragmatic instruction about how to deal with any ethical issues versus meeting stressful sales quotas. Sales managers must encourage professional conduct and not penalize individuals for acting ethically. Future research should test these recommendations for relative effectiveness.

Influence of the ethical context on job satisfaction

The results regarding the existence and communication of ethics codes, ethical context, and job satisfaction are generally consistent with the extant literature. A tertiary contribution is that these key associations are identified in the selling context. Specifically, the findings underscore that the ethical context, measured as CEV, provides a protective environmental boundary that encourages job satisfaction among selling professionals, while also limiting bullying experiences. Therefore, it is imperative for organizations to enhance and support the ethical context (Ferrell et al. 2007; McClaren 2013; Mulki, Jaramillo, and Locander 2006). The key question is: 'In addition to the presence and communication of ethics codes, what can organizations do environmentally and culturally to institutionalize ethical commitment among salespersons?'

First, sales managers must act in a manner that fosters salesperson trust, which is important for developing a robust ethical environment. Specifically, sales managers should strive to be consistent in both words and actions to set the proper 'tone at the top.' Furthermore, it is imperative that sales managers enforce a zero tolerance policy toward workplace bullying. In order to be effective, swift managerial disciplinary action must be taken against bona fide bullying acts, while taking special care to protect whistleblowers, both victims and observers, from retaliation. In sum, selling professionals need to be explicitly rewarded for ethical behavior and punished for unethical actions.

Second, sales managers need to spend considerable effort in designing fair and equitable sales quotas that consider the significant pressures salespeople endure (McClaren 2013). Managers should acknowledge that the gravity of achieving sales quotas often outweighs the burden to act ethically for many, especially when professionals are functioning in the field unobserved. Consequently, sales managers need to address subordinate skepticism about the importance and effectiveness of an ethical climate that delineates clear ethical boundaries.

Third, restructuring employees into teams may be necessary to reduce selling professionals' isolation, and increasing information sharing and task interdependence to better institutionalize ethical guidelines that foster enhanced job satisfaction is appropriate (McClaren 2013). Teams are especially important for new employees where the sales manager acts as a mentor/coach and role model regarding ethical guidelines and behavioral socialization protocols. Future research could investigate these three recommendations to assess their impact on the ethical context, job satisfaction, and bullying experiences.

Bullying experiences

One contribution of this study was assessing the influence of ethical context on workplace bullying. Hypothesis 2a highlighted that there is a significant negative relationship between CEV and workplace bullying. Therefore, the more salespeople struggled with bullying experiences, the less ethical they perceived their environment to be. It is not surprising that workplace bullying was also found to be negatively associated with job satisfaction. The ethics literature as a whole suggests that it is the ethical environment that influences employees, so people experiencing what they perceive to be bullying have a concomitant perception of a weak ethical environment. One of the strengths of an ethical environment is that severe bullying behaviors are not typically tolerated.

It is noteworthy that the mean for bullying experiences was just under a value of 3 (2.83) on a 7-point scale, so although bullying was not a serious issue for many employees, it certainly was a hindrance for some individuals in our sample as was expected. Just because the mean score for bullying was not as high as the scores for the other focal variables, it does not mean that bullying is unimportant. Furthermore, the 2013 National Business Ethics Survey reports that abusive behavior is usually a top-ranked ethical issue (NBES 2013). Given that negative associations between bullying and both CEV and job satisfaction were found, the key question is: 'What can sales managers do to mitigate bullying in their organizations?'

McClaren (2013, 110) suggests that there are 'appropriate safeguards to reduce problematic behavior' (which includes bullying and related deviant behaviors) that sales managers can build into the ethical environment. Specifically, he recommends focusing on *competitiveness* because this aspect of the sales profession is most likely associated with inappropriate conduct. There are numerous positive aspects of competition among members of the sales force that should be encouraged, but adverse competitive characteristics could potentially foster a culture of bullying and intimidation. Not surprisingly, bullies often utilize competitive tactics because they may be used successfully to intimidate others, thus providing a bully with an advantage in the workplace. To diffuse the negative aspects of competition, sales managers should encourage close supervisory relationships that emphasize ethics and promote a culture of altruistic leadership. This may be a particularly effective management strategy for diffusing an environment conducive to bullying because it fosters exactly the opposite orientation since serving and helping behaviors are promoted.

In addition to fostering an ethical work environment for selling professionals, another strategy involves using human resource practices to more effectively manage workplace deviance and bullying. For instance, potential bullies can be screened out during the hiring process so that they never enter the organization in the first place. Severe damage to the ethical context results when persons with bullying tendencies are promoted to sales manager positions. Research suggests that actual ethics tests be implemented as part of the salesperson hiring process (Honeycutt et al. 2001; Pettijohn, Pettijohn, and Taylor 2008; Schwepker 2003). Tests could include assessments of the ethical viewpoints of perspective sales employees, and individuals could be asked to evaluate ethical dilemmas that they might face, thus obtaining further information about their ethical tendencies. Finally, realistic job previews can be provided to job candidates so that they understand the demands associated with work in the sales profession (Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010).

Anecdotally, a common breakdown in the ethical environment is caused by bullies' deceptive nature, as they can often hide their so-called 'darker side' when they interact with management. Therefore, rank-and-file salespersons are likely aware of the bullying tendencies, but management may not be. The issue is especially acute when the 'closet bully' is an especially high performer, where management views them as simply competitive and high-achieving. In order for sales managers to stay in touch with their staff, it may be advisable to monitor sales employee job satisfaction and commitment, as well as their perceptions of the organizational ethical environment. Future longitudinal case study research could assess the effectiveness of altruistic leadership, the use of ethics tests, and the monitoring of employee job satisfaction to determine if such tactics reduce organizational bullying.

Contribution, summary, and conclusion

The theoretical insight of this investigation is that bullying is a new area to the sales ethics literature, and that it is an example of deviant behavior. As such, it represents an area of potentially interesting inquiry. Specifically, there has not been a study linking ethics codes to bullying in the sales context. Based on a review of current literature, only one sales study has addressed deviant behavior (Darrat, Amyx, and Bennett 2010). The findings also make a contribution from the standpoint that the communication of ethics codes and strengthening of CEV may improve ethical behavior by mitigating bullying. Another contribution is that these linkages may be used to enhance job satisfaction among selling professionals. A code of ethics is only one element of an effective corporate ethics program, and a code is a necessary condition for an ethical environment, but it is not sufficient for building an ethical context. The finding that codes must be effectively communicated to employees implies that an ethics code can simply serve as window dressing unless it is part of a well-communicated ethics program. In conclusion, the results suggest that sales managers must carefully build, review, and monitor the ethical context if they are to successfully mitigate bullying in their organizations.

Limitations and future research

Although this study significantly contributes to the sales ethics literature, there are a number of research limitations. For example, information was collected using a cross-sectional self-report survey, so same source bias could potentially be an issue. However, tests for this bias indicated that it was not a serious concern. The findings reflected associations, and no inferences regarding causality are intended. Since this questionnaire required respondents to voluntarily agree to participate, self-selection bias could have been an issue because respondents may reflect more altruistic characteristics compared to the general population of businesspersons. Responses from the national sample of selling professionals were acquired in two waves. The tests of differences between early and late responders suggested that nonresponse bias was not a concern. Due to response rate difficulty with the national sample, additional convenience sample data were gathered. A number of significant mean differences between the national and regional samples were identified, so a sample control variable was added to the analysis. Further, this investigation was unable to determine population averages for the demographic variables to further assess nonresponse bias and external validity. Since the study queried respondents about ethical issues, impression management could have been a factor and may have influenced the results. A control for social desirability was therefore included, and the analysis showed that impression management could have been impactful on several of the focal variables. The presence of these relationships provides further evidence that workplace bullying is a particularly sensitive issue in selling organizations, and that sales employees may be reluctant to share their experiences in an honest manner. Finally, given the specialized nature of the employees in our sample, generalizing the results to other workplace functions and occupations should be performed with caution.

Future research could longitudinally assess the construct relationships explored in this study. Using the case study method, three or four organizations could be investigated over time to assess how recommended changes to the ethical environment influence bullying experiences and job satisfaction on a pre- versus post-treatment basis. Other questions could also be investigated. For example, how do ethics training and communication programs, restructured sales quotas, and team-based altruistic leadership practices impact bullying experiences? Such research would provide further evidence about the importance of the ethical environment when managing bullying and related deviant behavior. The present study could be extended by exploring how salespersons' ethical sensitivity could be assessed when making selection and placement decisions, particularly in relation to how these predispositions prompt bullying. For instance, what ethics tests could be used to effectively identify potential bullies before they cause problems, and what attitudes and preferred behaviors are typical gateway characteristics that lead to bullying? Providing answers to these questions through additional research will provide more insight into how workplace bullying can be managed in selling organizations.

Acknowledgments

The authors thank O.C. Ferrell and Eric Arnould for their assistance with this research project.

Funding

Funding provided by the University of Wyoming was used to support this research.

Notes

1. The sampling frame was defined broadly to include a variety of employees who perform different selling activities in their firms (e.g., hospitality employees, customer contact workers, retail associates, real estate professionals, etc.).
2. Decisions were made based on whether individuals provided information for at least one of several sales-related

demographic items (establishing positive confirmation of selling activity), regardless of whether or not they claimed to be a sales profession.

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